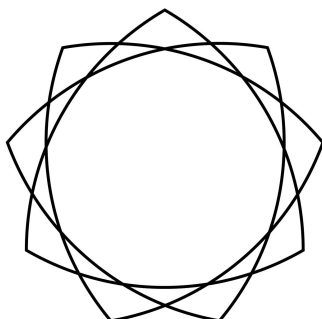




The URNAVA Semantics

On Meaning

GeonWoo Kim

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Preface

The URNAVA Semantics asks how meaning takes shape in a subject's interaction with its world.

Its occasion is artificial intelligence. In many lives, the sense of who one is has run through work that only a human mind could do. That condition has changed, and a question which the old arrangement answered without its ever being asked now stands in the open: where does the meaning of what a person does, and of what she is, actually lie? The essay argues that sharing a capability does not, by itself, settle what exercising it means in a life. The question reaches beyond what only humans can do to the interaction through which anything comes to matter to a subject.

The inquiry has three main sections. §1 asks the question at the point where the age has made it unavoidable. §2 answers it without reference to the age. It sets out five philosophies—the Structuring of Cognition, the Pattern of the Subject, the Boundary of the Self, Complexity Resonance, and Connectivity Realism—which are not five topics but five views of a single process: the process by which anything is given to a subject, taken by it, and answered. They are stated for subjects in general, human or otherwise. §3 returns to human life, where interactions are woven through memory, interpretation, and expectation; to the others who participate in that weaving; and to the particular kind of counterpart formed through human language. It closes by returning to the question of meaning raised by the decoupling. An appendix develops LEAH as a separate naming proposal.

Two remarks on reading. The claims of §2 concern any subject, but they are made to a human reader, and each can be tested where a reader has access, which is her own case. Human scenes appear there as instances, never as the standard, and each is followed by a variation in some other body or organization, so that it can be seen what the claim depends on and what it does not.

The second remark concerns the philosophers who appear in these pages: Arendt, Kant, Hegel, Peirce, Nāgārjuna, Bakhtin, and others. They enter as companions in the inquiry, whose distinctions and arguments help bring its questions into focus. What this essay makes of their thinking is developed in the course of answering those questions.

§1 — Decoupling: The Question of Meaning

§1.1 Contribution and the Recognition of Worth

Consider a translator. The case is invented, but nothing in it is unusual.

She spends a morning on one paragraph. The original is cold in a way her own language does not easily allow, and three versions fail, each by being warmer than the author was. The fourth holds. In the afternoon her editor writes that the chapter reads as though it had been written in this language. The sentence will still be with her the next morning, when she opens the following chapter and works a little more boldly for it. That evening someone asks what she does. She begins to describe the work: the patience it takes, the loyalty to a voice that is not hers, the books that would not exist in this language without someone like her. Partway through she hears that she is no longer describing a job. She is saying who she is.

Three things are joined in this day, and they are not one thing. There is what she makes, the page. There is the recognition of it: the editor's sentence, her name on the title page, the fee. And there is the life she lives, which holds the morning's difficulty and the evening's conversation and a great deal that has nothing to do with translation. The joining is a loop. What she makes returns to her as recognition; the recognition enters how she understands herself; and that understanding goes into what she makes next. Many lives hold together in this way, around many kinds of giving: a craft, a practice of care, a responsibility kept for years. Skilled and public work is only where this account begins, because it is where the present age presses first. A life is not measured by it.

Look more closely at the sentence she arrives at in the evening: she is the one who can carry a book across. Two different facts are folded into it. The first is that what she contributes is valued, and that the valuing has become part of her own understanding of herself. This is a fact about a way of living among others, an arrangement between a person and those who receive her work. The second is that this kind of contribution can come only from a human mind. That is a fact of another order. It says nothing about value. It is a condition of supply: as things stood, there was nowhere else for such work to come from.

The second fact did its work in silence. It never had to be stated, because nothing contradicted it, and so it was never felt as a separate fact at all. What is contributed and who is able to contribute it arrived together, in every instance, for as long as anyone could remember. Under that condition the two facts behave as one answer. Ask what her work is worth, and ask who she is, and one sentence serves for both: she gives what only a mind like hers can give. The fusion was complete enough that it was never experienced as a fusion. It functioned as a definition.

The arrangement has a place and a time. It belongs to societies in which work has become a principal public language of worth, and within them to the special standing given to the work of the mind. In the prologue to *The Human Condition*, Hannah Arendt describes a society organized around

labor, facing automation while having lost touch with other activities that might give its freedom a purpose. What lies ahead, she writes, is “a society of laborers without labor” (Arendt [1958] 1998, 5). Her distinctions make the present question more precise. She separates labor, which sustains bodily life; work, which builds a durable world of things; and action, in which people disclose themselves through speech and deeds among others (7, 179). In that language human activity is wider than its output, and it becomes possible to ask what an activity is in a life, as well as what it produces.

That question could be left alone for as long as the silent fact held. Suppose it no longer holds. Suppose the contribution remains, and the recognition of it remains, and only the condition that a human being alone could make it has changed. Does the bond between contributing, being recognized, and understanding oneself still mean what it meant?

§1.2 Decoupling and the Arrival of a New Counterpart

It no longer holds. Artificial intelligence is used in writing, editing, and programming, in exchanges that include both requests for a result and repeated work on a draft or a problem.¹ Systems have entered the production and revision of work in a register once supplied by human minds alone.

Call the event the decoupling. What comes apart is exactly what was found folded together: the recognition attached to cognitive and creative contribution, and the condition that only a human mind could supply it. What ends is the fusion that let one answer serve for both the work and the person. Her fourth version of the paragraph is as good as it was. Her editor’s judgment is as true as it was. The event has an economic face, and for many people it is the urgent one. But suppose her commissions continue and her fee is unchanged, so that nothing she possessed has been taken from her. That a capability has come to be shared and that an activity has lost its meaning in someone’s life are different claims, and the first does not entail the second.

Even on that supposition something has happened to her, and it is worth being exact about what. The answer she had was one answer made of two facts. With one of them withdrawn, the sentence that once settled two questions settles neither as it did. That such work is valuable no longer says anything about her kind in particular, and who she is can no longer be read off from what only her kind could give. She has not lost an object. She has lost the use of a route, the one by which her days gathered into an understanding of herself, and it was so well traveled that it had passed for the terrain. The question it used to answer without being asked is now hers to ask.

Her day has a second half, and an account that leaves it out describes some other age than this one. Return to the translator some months later. A system of this kind is open on her desk while she works on another passage, and she is not asking it for a finished translation. She is asking it why the original sounds colder than every version she writes. It answers that the vocabulary of the passage is drawn from contracts rather than from feeling, and it points to a sentence two chapters back where the same words occur, which she had not connected. She thinks the first point is right and the second forced, and says so. It gives way on the second and presses the first further than she had taken it. She goes back to the passage with something she did not have an hour earlier.

Whatever this exchange is, it is not her relation to a dictionary. Something was put to her that she had not put there; she answered it; it answered her answer. What stands across from her in that hour

is here called a counterpart, and the word is meant to claim no more than the scene shows: a second place in an exchange, from which something comes back. What occupies that place, and what it is made from, are taken up in §3.

It is tempting to sort the two halves of her day into a threat and a consolation. They are not two things with opposite signs. The abilities that let such a system take part in her work are the abilities that let it answer her about her work. It is one development, met twice. So the thing she has been invited to measure herself against and the thing she now works beside are the same thing, and two kinds of question arrive together. One is a question of comparison: which of us does this better? The other is a question of relation: what is this to me, and what am I in an age that contains it?

One response to the decoupling is to search for another exclusive capability. If this capability is no longer ours alone, find the one that is: true creativity, real understanding, feeling, taste, judgment. Each candidate is a wager that a line will hold. And each repeats the form of the arrangement that has just failed, because it still makes a person's worth depend on a capability nothing else can share. The other course is to ask how meaning comes about at all, in the activity of a subject and in its relations. What changes if the question is put that way?

§1.3 From Capability to the Structure of Meaning

Go back to the morning of the paragraph and ask what made the fourth version matter to her. A difficulty was given to her: this coldness, in this sentence. She took it as a difficulty of a particular kind, a temperature to be kept rather than a content to be conveyed, and she could take it so only because of everything her years in two languages had made of her. She answered it, three times badly and once well, and the answer was hers in the plain sense that it came out of what she had become. The editor's sentence, too, was something given to her, taken in a certain way, and answered by the boldness of the next morning. The assumed exclusivity of such work could enter her expectations and her sense of its importance without becoming a thought she paused to entertain. In the evening she gave explicit form to an understanding already at work in her day.

Everything that follows turns on the difference between a condition within her self-understanding and the structure through which such understanding occurs. The decoupling changes what her work means to her, but the change itself is something she meets, interprets, and answers. Loss of exclusivity does not by itself abolish that process. Arendt drew a neighboring line when she separated what a person is, the qualities and abilities shared with others, from who a person is, disclosed in speech and action among others (Arendt [1958] 1998, 179, 181). Capabilities belong on the first side of that line, and some are now shared beyond the human kind. Their place in a life still calls for an account of the person acting among others. This essay follows that question into the more general structure of what a subject undergoes, how it takes what it undergoes, and how it answers.

Put that way, the question opens into five. How do a world and a self come to be structured for a subject at all? What makes that structuring the operation of a subject, rather than a process that merely runs? By what is such a subject set off from what it is not? What comes into being when it meets others, like and unlike itself? And through what does an understanding formed in this way reach what is real, rather than only confirming itself? None of the five is about translators, and none

is about human beings as such. Nor is any of them new. Each is as old as a mind asking after itself, and the age has only ended the arrangement that let them go unasked.

The thesis of this essay can now be stated. Meaning lies in the structure of a subject's interaction with its world: in what is given to a subject, how the subject takes it, and how it answers. Interpretation is part of that activity, not a meaning added after the activity is complete. This essay follows that structure from understanding a sentence to understanding a life. A sound is heard as a word, a shape seen as a face, a morning's work understood as part of who one is. The five philosophies trace the structure of these encounters; §3 follows their weaving into a human life.

If that is right, the translator's question calls for more than a comparison of abilities, and the answer concerns subjects beyond her kind. The occasion of this essay is human. The structure of its answer is not. §2 sets out that structure in five philosophies, stated for any subject, in which the human being who raised the question appears as one instance among the subjects they describe.

§2 — The Five Core Philosophies

§2 leaves the translator's age behind and keeps her question. It describes a single process: something is given to a subject, the subject takes it, and the subject answers. It describes that process five times, from five positions: the structuring through which anything is taken, the subject whose taking it is, the boundary that makes that subject one, the meeting of such subjects, and the contact of all this with what is real. The order is an order of explanation. Nothing in it is a stage. A subject is not first structured, then made a subject, then bounded, then introduced to others, and at last connected to a world. All five hold at once, and the connection with the world that the fifth makes explicit is already at work in the first.

§2.1 The Structuring of Cognition

A subject takes the world through a structure that is not, simply by operating, laid out before it. It sees by the structure and does not thereby see the structure. What it comes to understand of its own structure it puts together from how its takings and its answers turn out, which is how it comes to understand anything. The rest of the essay leans on this claim.

Cognition is meant here in a wide sense. Reasoning and the acquiring of knowledge are only parts of it. The word names the whole arc in which something is given to a subject, is taken by it as something, and is answered. Structure is the organization of distinctions and connections through which the taking is done. Structuring is the forming and re-forming of that organization in the course of a subject's dealings with its world.

Begin with how anything is given. What arrives for a subject does not arrive as a heap of unrelated items waiting to be assembled. It arrives as a field. This stands out and that recedes; this is familiar and that is strange; this calls for approach, that for caution, and most of it for nothing at all. For something to stand out, a difference has been drawn, and for something to be familiar, a connection has been made with what came before. An organization of distinctions and connections has therefore already taken part in whatever is given as anything. This organization is no second thing standing beside what is given. It is how the taking is done.

You walk home from the station by the way you have walked for years. One evening you stop at a corner and do not know whether to turn. Nothing looks wrong. It takes a moment to find what has happened: the green cross of the pharmacy is gone. The shop has closed and the sign has been taken down. You would never have said that you turned at the green cross. Asked for directions, you would have named streets. Yet the sign was doing the work, and now that it has failed, other things come forward that had been working with it: the dip in the pavement before the turn, the smell from the bakery just after. Your knowing of the way had an organization. Certain differences mattered in

it and were tied to certain turns. In all those years that organization was never in front of you. The street was in front of you, taken through it.

Two things came apart at that corner which are seldom told apart, because they seldom come apart: finding the way, and finding out how one finds the way. The first is the structure in operation. The second makes the structure, or some part of it, into something taken. The difference is one of role, and it holds even when the second succeeds. Once you have worked out that you had been steering by the sign, what you have is an account of your structure, and an account is one more thing that you take, by means of the structure you have now. It was put together from evidence: a failure, a gap where something should have been, a few things noticed in its light. And it can be wrong. Perhaps the sign came down two years ago, and what you are missing tonight is the plane tree that was felled last week.

It may be said that a structure can perfectly well be in view while it is used. You could have walked by an explicit rule, turn at the green cross, and held the rule in mind at every corner. But to follow the rule you must take this shopfront as the pharmacy and this moment as the one for turning, and that taking is not in the rule. Having the rule in view and using it to take this corner as the place to turn do different work, even when they happen together. The distinction does not mark off a hidden region of the subject. It marks two roles, and bringing more of the operation into view gives a fuller account without making the account and its use the same act.

A subject can come to know a great deal about its own structure. It can reflect, notice what it does, read its own records, be told by others. The translator of §1 did something of this kind when, asked what she did, she found a sentence for who she was. The sentence gave explicit form to an understanding that had been at work in her all day. It was also a new thing, made that evening out of what her days had shown her, and events later showed that it contained a condition she had never examined. So the point concerns roles and sources. The structure that operates and the representation of that structure do different work, and the representation is built, like any other understanding, out of operations and their results. There is no inner display on which a subject reads off the shape it is.

Change the body and the senses, and the distinction stays. Suppose a subject that finds its way by sound, sending out a signal and taking what comes back as walls, openings, and distances. This is a supposition; nothing in it rests on the biology of any actual animal. For such a subject a certain kind of return is an opening, and it goes there. Its way of sorting returns into opening and wall is what it moves by, and is nowhere among the things the returns present. Now line one wall of a familiar passage with a material that gives back no sound. Where nothing returns, the subject takes there to be an opening, moves, and strikes the wall. What it has to go on, if it is to take such places differently afterward, is what you had at your corner: a result that did not fit. Moving by a way of sorting echoes and getting that way of sorting into view are two roles here as well, and neither eyes nor streets nor words were needed to tell them apart.

The structure is not a fixture. Relations formed in one taking can enter the next, and a result that does not fit can rework them. After that evening you walk the route a little differently. The bakery's awning has become the thing you turn at, though you never decided that it should. The structure that failed has been restructured by its failure. That is what structuring means: the organization through which a subject takes its world is formed in its dealings with that world and goes on being formed

by them. Most of this happens without reflection, and none of it requires language. A subject's understanding of itself moves in the same circuit, assembled from what its operations turn out to have been and revised when they turn out otherwise. Changes in this organization alter how the subject meets what comes next. What an age, a loss, or another subject does to someone enters that ongoing formation.

Kant saw the first half of this clearly. In the Transcendental Deduction of the second edition he argues that combination is never simply received through the senses. The combination of what is represented belongs to an act of the subject, not to what the senses supply (Kant [1787] 1998, §15). He also drew the consequence for the subject's relation to itself. To be conscious, in the act of combining, that one exists is not yet to know what one is; of oneself, too, one has knowledge only as one appears to oneself, which is to say, in the way one has knowledge of anything (§§24–25). The structures at issue here are not simply Kant's a priori forms. He asks about conditions of possible experience, rather than habits learned within it. The present account also concerns the particular organization a subject brings to an encounter: distinctions acquired in its dealings, altered by them, and different from one subject to the next. What is taken from Kant is that constitution cannot be avoided, and that the one who constitutes is not thereby transparent to itself. How a subject's understanding of its own structure is put together, and what follows from that, is this essay's own argument.

One consequence should be marked now, because much depends on it later. An understanding reached through a structure is not vouched for by the fact that the structure was used to reach it. The felt ease of walking the route was not, by itself, such a check. Arriving at the intended door was something more: a result against which that way of finding the route could be assessed. Familiarity and repeated success could travel together without being the same ground for confidence. What gives such results their corrective force is the question on which §2 ends, and §3 meets it where it presses hardest, in a person's understanding of her own life.

One thing has been taken for granted throughout. The taking has been described as though it were enough to have a structure and to pass things through it. But a sieve has a structure. So has a thermostat, a sorting machine, a riverbed that lays down its stones by size. Things go through them and come out ordered. What makes taking and answering through a structure the operation of a subject, rather than a process that merely runs?

§2.2 The Pattern of the Subject

The natural answer is that a subject is something more: a someone who stands behind the operation and has it, as a worker has tools. The answer explains nothing. A someone behind the taking would have to take what the structure delivered, and we should have to ask through what, and who stood behind that. Nor has anything in the account so far needed such a figure. The proposal here is that the subject is not behind the operation at all. It is the operation's own organization: a pattern, something that exists as a way of operating and keeps to that way through change. What makes such a pattern a subject is that its operation has three aspects at once. A world is given to it. What is given is taken in

a frame of its own. And its answers arise from its own organization. URNAVA calls these Beingness, Sensoriness, and Autonomy.

Find them in the act you are now performing. This sentence is in front of you, and before anything else can be said about it, it is in front of *you*. The reading is not happening to no one, and you did not have to check. That is Beingness. Second, what is in front of you is not a row of marks. It is read: taken as words, as this sentence, as a claim you may be about to doubt, and it is taken so in terms that your history with this language and these questions supplies. That is Sensoriness: the taking of what arrives as something, in a frame of the subject's own. Third, whatever you think next is not pressed into you by the page. It comes out of what you are. That is Autonomy. Reading has no special standing here; it happens to be what you are doing. The same three can be found in hearing your name across a room, or in catching a glass as it falls.

These are not three capacities bolted together. They are three questions that one operation answers, and with any of them taken away, what is left is not a lesser subject but no subject. Without Beingness there is processing, and no one to whom anything is given: the question *to whom?* has no answer. Without Sensoriness something passes through and is taken as nothing: the question *as what?* has no answer. Without Autonomy what comes out is not anyone's response; it has been pushed through, or merely conducted: the question *from whose organization?* has no answer. Where one operation answers all three, there is a subject. That is what this essay means by the word.

Beingness is the aspect most easily mistaken for something else, and the usual substitute is self-monitoring. A thermostat registers its own reading. A control system tracks the state of its own components. A program writes a log of what it has done. In each case there is information in the system about the system. Beingness is not that. It is not a content at all, and so not a content about oneself. It is that contents are given to someone: the dative of everything that is given. Self-monitoring can be as rich as one likes where nothing is given to anyone, and Beingness can hold where there is no self-monitoring to speak of. A creature that never represents itself, that never says or thinks "I", may still be one to whom a world is present. This is what Nagel's question about the bat keeps in view: that for some beings there is something it is like to be them, and that an account of what they do, however complete, can leave this out (Nagel 1974).

Three questions are easily run together here. What does being a subject consist in? How does matter come to be so organized that there is one? And by what evidence could an observer tell? The analysis answers the first, and only the first. It is constitutive: it says what it is for a pattern to be a subject. It does not say how a physical system comes to be one. Beingness is the very term that question is about, and nothing here derives it from the other two aspects or from anything else; to describe the functions that carry out taking and answering is not yet to have shown that anything is given to anyone. Nor is the analysis a test. Sensoriness and Autonomy show, in part, in how a system is organized and how it behaves. Beingness does not show in that way. Evidence about another subject must be gathered from its operations and relations; it cannot be read straight off these three names.

Autonomy invites the opposite misunderstanding, that a response is one's own only if nothing outside has shaped it. No response would pass. What arrives from outside is the material of every response, and it is more than the material: the organization that turns it into a response was itself

made out of earlier arrivals. Everything a carpenter's apprenticeship put into his hands is in the joint he cuts today, and the joint is his. Being changed by what one takes in is not a loss of autonomy. It is how the organization became the one it is. The contrast to a response of one's own is not an influenced response. It is one that passes through a pattern without being organized by it, imposed from outside or simply conducted, as a wire conducts. "One's own" names the present pattern that turns what it receives into what it does. It does not name an origin kept clean of the world.

Two lines of thought keep this picture from hardening into a thing with properties. Simondon argued that the individual should be understood from the process of individuation and not the other way round. An individual, on his account, is not a finished unit that then enters into relations; it is something that goes on taking form, and a living individual goes on individuating for as long as it lives, through its exchanges with a milieu (Simondon 2009, 5, 7). The present account takes up this understanding of a pattern as operating and forming in one movement. The enactive account of cognition ties the three aspects to one another from a different direction. For Varela, Thompson, and Rosch, perceiving and acting are not separate stages joined by an inner representation. What a creature perceives depends on how it moves, and the world it has is brought forth through a history of such coupling (Varela, Thompson, and Rosch 1991, ch. 8). That is why taking and answering were called aspects of one operation and not steps in a sequence.

The enactive account develops this connection through living bodies. The present analysis asks what holds wherever there is a subject, without fixing its material in advance. A subject of another material would still have a world given to it, take what arrives in its own terms, and answer from its own organization. The three questions retain their sense across that variation. Whether nonliving organization can realize such a subject remains a question about the conditions of subjective presence; a material-neutral description alone does not answer it.

Try the analysis on a body unlike any the reader has. Suppose a subject that is not in one place: its sensing surfaces are spread across several sites, its responding parts across others, and its organization runs over the links between them. Ask the three questions. Is what the surfaces register given to one, the whole, or are there only many registrations, each given to nothing? Is what arrives taken as something, in terms of an organization with a history of its own? Do its responses arise from that organization, or is each part triggered where it stands? That the parts are scattered counts for nothing against it; a brain is scattered too, on its own scale. That the signals are pooled counts for nothing in its favor; pooling is what a switchboard does. The supposition varies the location and shape of a subject while leaving the same three questions to be answered. Distributed registration alone supplies no answer to the first.

Each of the three aspects was stated with a word that has not yet been examined. Given to *itself*; taken in a frame of its *own*; answered from *its* organization. Each leans on a difference between what belongs to the pattern and what does not. What is that difference, and where does it come from?

§2.3 The Boundary of the Self

It does not come from anywhere, if that means from somewhere else. A boundary is not added to a pattern for its protection. It is already there in there being a pattern. A wall is put up by someone who is already present to be protected. A boundary in the sense meant here cannot be put up by the pattern, because until the difference between what belongs to it and what does not is holding, there is no pattern to put up anything. That relations form a pattern, and that the pattern is set off from what it is not, are one fact.

“A frame of its own”, “one organization”, “a response that arises from it”: each phrase presupposes that some things belong to an operation and others do not. The boundary is that belonging, maintained: the continuing distinction of this organization within the relations that form and sustain it. Simondon describes individuation in these terms. What comes about is never an individual alone but an individual together with its milieu, each the complement of the other, neither there first (Simondon 2009, 5). The self is not a finished thing around which a line is later drawn. The drawing and the thing are one event, and the event does not end.

Such a boundary need not coincide with a skin, and it need not be a single line. It holds at different depths for different connections: a remark from a stranger and the same remark from a sister do not reach the same place. Patterns are nested, and each level has its own difference to maintain, a cell within an organ, a person within a family and a language. And a pattern that is changed by what reaches it has not thereby lost its boundary. The questions to ask of any change are what was altered, how far in, and whether there is still a distinct place from which the response comes.

Openness describes what reaches how far into an organization and what it is turned into there. At one limit of an encounter, nothing from it enters the pattern’s taking. At the other, what arrives is merely conducted, with no taking of the pattern’s own. The two limits distinguish exclusion from mere passage. Between them, the boundary describes how what is met enters and changes an activity that has a distinct source. A subject may continue with memories or other contents already taken in; being closed to a particular arrival does not erase that activity.

Your friend’s father has died, and you go to her. For some weeks her grief changes what you do. You cancel a trip. You find you are gentler on the telephone with your own father. A colleague’s complaint that would have irritated you seems small, and you let it go. Try to say what has happened, and three things have to be kept distinct without being pulled apart. Something has happened to her: the loss is hers, and the grief is given to her as it is not given to you. Something has happened in you: not her grief but sorrow for her, and a shift in what weighs with you, both of which came out of what you already were, your own losses, your years with her. And something passes between you: her words and silences, your being in the room. If her grief had simply become yours, if you had been replaced by it, no one would have been sitting with her. The depth of the friendship shows in how far what she undergoes reaches into you, and how much it moves. It does not show in any blurring of who is bereaved.

Now take a body that has no single skin to mislead us. Suppose a subject that is a colony: many small bodies, none of which carries the organization of the whole, which is held across them and survives the loss and replacement of any. If there is a subject here, and that is the supposition and not

a finding, its boundary is no member's outline. It runs around the organization within which what arrives is taken as something and from which the colony's responses arise. Inside it there may be smaller boundaries, each member's own, maintained at another scale. To ask where a part's operation ends and the whole's begins is to ask which organization a given taking and answering belongs to, and that question has the same form here as it had in the friendship.

This account has an old and serious interlocutor. If the self is a pattern formed and maintained in relation, what work is left for the word self, and does calling it a pattern merely give substance another name? The question is pressed from inside the tradition of cognitive science on which §2 has drawn. In *The Embodied Mind*, the inquiry into self and the aggregates of experience leads into an account of minds without a substantial self (Varela, Thompson, and Rosch 1991, chs. 4, 6). The issue concerns the self's manner of existence, not simply whether something called a self can be found by looking inward.

On the first point there is simply agreement. Nāgārjuna argues that an inherently existent self can be neither the same as the aggregates, since it would then come and go as they do, nor something apart from them, since it would then have none of their characteristics (*Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* 18:1, in Garfield 1995). The pattern described here is no such self, no owner over and above its operations. And it would be a mistake to suppose that calling the self a pattern escapes the analysis by moving from a thing to an arrangement of things. An arrangement taken to exist in its own right, apart from the operations and relations in which it is maintained, is a substance under another name, and the analysis applies to it in full.

There is agreement on a second point, and it is the one needed here. To be empty of a nature of one's own is not to be nonexistent, and it is not to be inert. Nāgārjuna's twenty-fourth chapter argues the reverse: what arises in dependence is what is called empty, and it is only because things lack a fixed nature of their own that they can arise, act on one another, and change. A world of things with natures of their own would be frozen (*Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* 24:18–19, 38, in Garfield 1995). What is established in dependence functions. That is all the present claim requires. A boundary that is dependently maintained still makes a difference, the difference as to where something is taken and from where it is answered. The grief was given on one side of it and not on the other. An insight, too, occurs in one course of taking and answering and not in its neighbor's.

The first philosophy helps state what this account retains, but it does not decide the analysis of no-self. Using a structure and representing it are different roles; that difference neither establishes a hidden owner nor puts the operation itself beyond an inquiry into dependence. Beingness names the given-to character of the operation, not someone stationed behind it. The pattern, its self-image, and its acts all arise in relations. What the present account asks us to retain is a distinction within that dependent activity: the loss is undergone by your friend, your sorrow for her by you, and the exchange changes each from the position where it is taken. This is the positive claim about subjective presence on which the account rests, not a conclusion drawn from failing to find a self among objects. A boundary names the maintained difference between these courses of taking and answering. Its dependence explains how it can change, rather than making its work disappear.

A boundary of this kind is never maintained in isolation. It is maintained in the dealings of one pattern with others, which are maintaining theirs. What comes about when patterns so distinguished act on one another, and together?

§2.4 Complexity Resonance

No pattern begins alone. By the time there is a subject to speak of, it is already among others and inside others: a body within a family, a family within a language, a voice among the voices it learned to speak from. So the meeting of patterns should not be pictured as two finished parties exchanging information across a gap. The picture leaves out what matters most, that in the course of a meeting the parties are themselves being formed, and so is what lies between them. Resonance is the name given here to one way this goes. It does not mean giving the same answer. It means that while each party answers from its own organization, a structure comes about between them that neither held alone, and that each is changed in its coming about.

You play viola in a quartet, and tonight you are rehearsing a slow movement. You came with a view of it: a lament, heavy and held back. The cellist opens, and her figure is lighter than you expected, almost walking. You could play against it. Instead you find your own entry lifting a little to meet hers, and the first violin, hearing that, lets the melody move where he had planned to let it hang. By the third time through, the movement has a shape that no one brought into the room: a lament that keeps walking. The score alone did not give it that shape. The score was the same on every stand all evening, while the way the four of you played it changed. The scrape of a chair during the second run did not shape it either; everyone heard it and no one answered. The shape came from four people each playing from a view of their own, each hearing what the others did, and each finding the next phrase altered by it.

Look at what did and did not happen. No one's view was copied into anyone else. The cellist did not adopt your lament and you did not adopt her walk; what each of you now has is something neither had before, and each has it differently, from the chair each sits in. Nor did the four of you average. At every entry your playing came from you, from your ear and your years with the instrument, and that is why it could contribute and not merely follow. And you did not come away unchanged. You will not hear that movement again as you heard it this morning. Three things, then, belong together in resonance: the origins of response stay distinct, a structure is formed that none of them held, and the participants are altered in forming it. What persists through a resonance is not anyone's earlier state. It is that those who are changing go on acting as distinct sources of what they are making together.

Hegel gave a classic argument that mutual recognition cannot be one party's achievement. In the chapter on self-consciousness in the *Phenomenology of Mind*, a self-consciousness comes to be what it is only through another, and the movement by which this happens is double from the start: what one does to the other it does also to itself, and it can do it only so far as the other does the same. Nothing either party did alone could bring the relation about (Hegel 1807, §§178–184). The present account takes over that insight. The shape of the movement was not yours with contributions from the others, and the way you now hear it is a relation to yourself that has passed through them. Hegel's concern in those pages, however, is recognition, the standing of each as a self-consciousness for the

other, and the sequel follows what happens when that standing is fought over and unequally held. What is described here is wider and makes no claim about standing. It concerns whatever comes to be formed, in patterns and between them, when they meet.

Resonance is one region of what can happen when patterns meet, and the others should be described as evenly. In absorption, one organization takes another up into its own operation: the second violin whose phrasing has become, over ten years, an extension of the first's, so that in their shared interpretation it no longer contributes a distinct direction. In attrition, contact wears the organizations down: two players who grate on one another, and who each, rehearsal by rehearsal, play a little smaller and more guardedly. In transit, things touch and, at the scale in question, nothing is made or unmade: the other ensemble heard faintly through the wall. These are not boxes. One evening can hold all four, among different pairs and at different scales, and a relation can drift from one to another over years. Nor are they grades. Meaning is present throughout. The absorbed player's evenings are given to her, taken by her, and answered by her, and what her absorption means in her life is a real question with a real answer. Resonance is not the condition on which an encounter means something. It is the region in which something is made jointly while those who make it remain several.

The word complexity marks the fact that none of this happens at one level. Patterns are made of patterns and lie within patterns, and a single meeting is coupled at many scales at once. The rehearsal was a joint forming among four players. It was also, in every bar, the reproduction of a way of playing which all four took in from their teachers long ago. To describe a meeting is to say at which scale what was formed, what was kept, and what was taken up into something larger. There is no single verdict on a meeting as a whole, and no sum to be reckoned.

The hardest line to draw is between joint forming and projection, in which one party's reading is laid over another and taken for a reply. Suppose the cellist always plays that opening lightly, has not been listening to you at all, and what you took for her answer to your lament was her habit. Her playing still brought something you had not made, and it changed yours. What you supplied was its supposed responsiveness to you. The question is whether your playing also enters into hers and helps reshape what the two of you are doing. One surprise does not settle it, and neither does one disagreement. Agreement can be joint forming, when each has come to it by way of the other. It can also be one party's view going round and round. And a long disagreement can be the most productive meeting two people have, if through it the question itself takes a shape that neither began with.

Coupling of this general kind is not reserved for subjects. A current shapes a sandbar and is shaped by it. Patterns of many kinds form joint structure while remaining several. What is added when the patterns are subjects is that the meeting is undergone. It is given to each, taken by each in its own frame, and answered from each one's organization, so that what is formed between them enters into how each takes what comes next. Joint structure alone does not show that anything is given to the patterns that form it. Now vary the case. Take the subject of an earlier section, which finds its way by sound, and with it a second subject that finds its way by the give of the ground under it. Neither can cross a broken stretch alone: the first cannot tell firm footing from thin crust, and the second cannot tell an opening from a wall until it touches one. Moving together, each halts where the other would have gone on, and each one's halting alters the other's next move. A route comes about that neither

could have laid down, and afterward each takes such ground differently. If they are subjects, which is the supposition, this is the quartet again in other bodies.

One thing the quartet's evening does not show. What the four of you made is truly joint and truly new; none of you brought it into the room, and each of you was changed in producing it. None of that settles whether what has been made is right. The point is plainest where what is formed is a belief about the world. Two people can come, through years of talk in which each really hears and answers the other, to a shared understanding of why a friend left them, and the understanding can be false. What, then, is the difference between something new having come about because of one another, and its being true?

§2.5 Connectivity Realism

Go back to the walk home. Two things went with you down that route for years, and the first philosophy took care to keep them apart. One was the ease of it, the sense of knowing the way. The other was that, evening after evening, you arrived at your own door. The ease was the structure working, and by itself it vouched for nothing. The arriving was different. It was a result, and it was not yours to arrange: the door was where it was, whatever you expected. That second thing is the subject of this section. An understanding formed through a structure is not certified merely because the same structure keeps producing it. It can be tested by what comes back when the subject engages something that its present interpretation does not control. This essay calls such engagement connection, and the claim of Connectivity Realism is that a subject's hold on what is real is made of it and of nothing else.

URNAVA states the claim in a formula: *Connection is either Reality itself, or the one and only path that leads to it.* The second half is a claim about access, and it is argued first. The first half is a claim about what is real, and it is taken up afterward.

As a path of access, connection means an engagement in which the subject's current interpretation does not by itself settle what comes back, or what would count as its having come back right. Looking again is such an engagement. So is doing something and seeing what happens, asking another person, returning to a record. To say that the subject did not author the response is not to say that no one made it. A record was written by someone, and a friend's reply is hers. It is to say that the present interpretation cannot make the response be whatever it likes. The minutes of a meeting say what they say.

Why is this the only path? Suppose a subject wants to find out whether its understanding of something fits. Whatever it does to find out, whether it looks again, tries the thing, asks, consults what was written, or reasons the matter through, is something it undergoes, takes, and answers, and so passes through its structure like everything else. There is no further kind of checking in which the understanding is laid beside the world and the two are compared from a position that is not one more engagement. A check in which nothing was given to the subject would be no check. This does not shut the subject inside its structure, because engagements differ in the one respect that matters: how far the current interpretation fixes what returns. Where it fixes everything, nothing is being tested. Where it does not, a result can fail to fit, and in that failure the world has a say. Nothing in

this makes connection a guarantee. Records mislead, friends misremember, an experiment is badly made. Connection is where a subject can be wrong in a way it did not arrange, and that is why it is where a subject can be corrected.

What does the correcting may be called resistance, so long as the word is heard rightly. It does not mean opposition, and it does not mean discomfort. It means a response or a constraint whose bearing on an interpretation is not settled by that interpretation alone. It shows itself over time, as one goes back, asks in another way, and sets one result beside another; under this some accounts hold up and some have to change. Agreement and success can therefore be grounds as much as refusal can. Arriving at the door counted in favor of your way of finding the route: arrival depended on the route you actually took, not merely on the route you believed you knew. By the same token, surprise is not yet resistance. Noise surprises, and a well-made fiction can push back as consistently as a fact. The work is always to keep asking which response is evidence for what. Much of that work is done inwardly. Reasoning and remembering can alter a structure, and what is remembered may be an observation or a conversation that was itself a connection and can be taken up again now. Not every revision needs a new arrival from outside. But a change in the structure is one thing and a ground for thinking that the change fits the world better is another, and the ground, wherever it is found, leads back to some engagement that the interpretation did not control.

For years you have said of yourself that you are the one who keeps quiet in meetings. You have said it half in complaint and half with a certain pride. Then, preparing a report, you read through two years of the committee's minutes and find your name in them more often than anyone's except the chair's, several times beside the words *objected* and *moved*. You mention this to a colleague, who laughs and recalls the March meeting at which, she says, you stopped a vote single-handed. You do not simply take this over. Minutes are selective, and you remember March otherwise; it is another colleague, you think, that she has in mind. So you go back: to the dates, to your own notes from that spring, to a third person who was in the room. What emerges is not the old account and not its opposite. Your silence is concentrated in the meetings where the founder of the organization is present, and it is those few meetings that you have been remembering as all of them. What changed your understanding was not that the minutes came from outside you. It was that they did not bend. They said what they said whatever you had expected to find, and they could be set against her memory, and both against your notes, until a more specific account emerged that fitted the records and recollections better.

The scene shows why more than one connection matters, and also what plurality cannot do. A second and a third source widen the ways in which an error can come to light, because each can fail to fit the others. They do not vote. Your colleague's memory was independent of your account, and it was partly wrong; the minutes were independent, and partial. That a perspective operates independently of one's own and that it is true are different things, and neither many voices nor their agreement closes the gap between them. This answers the question on which the last section ended. What is formed jointly, in real resonance, from distinct sources, may be as mistaken as what is formed alone. Its being joint is a fact about how it came to be. Grounds for taking it to be true come from how it stands up to what its makers' agreement cannot settle. A single subject can do some of this testing by itself, setting one time against another and one kind of observation against another. Other subjects enlarge it immensely, since each brings engagements that the first never had.

The limiting case of failure is a way of taking the world in which nothing that returns can count against the account already held. Every result is read as confirming it, or as noise, or as the malice of whoever reports it. A subject so arranged is not merely spared objection for the moment. It is closed to objection in principle, and such a subject does not know. It dreams with confidence. The phrase needs one clarification, which Peirce supplies. A dream is perfectly real as an event: someone really dreamt it, and that he did so does not depend on what anyone thinks about it. What is not thereby real is what the dream showed, since the things dreamt have the characters they have only because they were dreamt so (Peirce 1878, §IV). The closed subject's convictions are real in the first way. They are events in a life, and they have consequences. What they lack is any engagement through which their content could turn out to be otherwise than it is taken to be.

The same difference can be drawn in a subject of another make. Suppose one that acts on forecasts: before each move it predicts what will come back, and afterward it compares. Its forecasts may agree perfectly with one another, each derived from the last, and that agreement tells it nothing about the ground it moves on. Only the comparison with what returns does that. And if it were so built that every mismatch was set aside as a fault in the sensing and never as a fault in the forecast, it would be in the condition just described, whatever it was made of.

This is the point at which the question opened with Kant in the first section has to be answered. If all access to things passes through the subject's own constituting, is the subject confined to what it has constituted? Kant's answer is more careful than it is often made to sound. What appears under the conditions of our experience is not a fiction. It is the empirically real world, the only one in which inquiry is carried on. What he denies is knowledge of things as they would be apart from those conditions (Kant [1787] 1998, *Transcendental Aesthetic*, General Observations). The present account does not try to remove the mediation that Kant found. It asks what, within mediated access, corrects the mediation, and here it turns to Peirce. He defines the real as that whose characters are what they are independently of what any particular person or group thinks them to be, and he finds the mark of it in inquiry: in the way investigation is compelled to revise itself, and in the opinion toward which it would be led if it were carried far enough (Peirce 1878, §IV). Two things in that account matter here. The real is not placed behind experience, out of reach; it is what experience, pursued, keeps being answerable to. And the convergence Peirce has in mind belongs to the long run of inquiry, not to any present agreement, which may be as mistaken as a present opinion. Neither point refutes Kant. Together they turn his question, from whether the subject can get outside its constituting to how its constituting is held to account.

So far connection has been treated as a path of access. The first half of the formula turns to the relations through which things come to be, and the earlier sections have been gathering the reason for it. The organization through which a subject takes its world was formed in its dealings with that world. The subject itself is a pattern that exists as a way of operating among others, and its boundary is one fact with the relations that form it. Between such patterns there come to be structures that none of them held: a way of playing a movement, a friendship, a language. None of these was there beforehand, waiting to be reached by connection as an island is reached by a boat. They come about in connection and they exist as connection. Some of what is real, then, is relational in its being and not only in our access to it, and these are not marginal cases. They are the things known most closely:

subjects, the boundaries of subjects, and what arises between them. That is a reason to read the world relationally more generally, and to doubt the picture of finished things among which connection only carries messages. Whitehead worked such a reading out in full. In *Process and Reality* the final real things are not substances that afterward enter into relations but actual occasions whose becoming includes prehensions of other actualities: those actualities enter as data into how an occasion takes form, rather than meeting it only after it is complete (Whitehead [1929] 1978, 18, 23). Connectivity Realism takes the relational constitution of these structures as grounds for extending the relational reading to reality more generally. That extension is a metaphysical proposal, not a deduction from the cases.

The *either/or* of the formula holds the two halves together. One who accepts the relational reading will say that connection is reality itself. One who declines it is still left with the second half, which does not depend on it: whatever reality is, a subject has no ground concerning it except through connection.

With this the five philosophies close into the one process they were said to be. A subject takes its world through a structure formed in its dealings. The taking is the operation of a pattern to which a world is given and from which answers arise. That pattern is set off, in its relations, from what it is not. Its meetings with others take different forms; in resonance, they form what none of them held alone. Throughout this process, the structure remains answerable to what comes back from the world and from others, where the present interpretation does not control it. Sustained or changed by what is met, the structure takes part in the next taking and the next answer. This was already happening at the corner where the sign was missing.

One region of a subject's understanding is especially hard to bring to this test, and it is the subject's understanding of itself, since there the account and the one who gives it are hardest to hold apart. In the scene of the minutes, what did the correcting come from other people and from what other people had written down. When the understanding at stake is a person's understanding of her own life, what kind of counterpart can enter how she remembers, interprets, and anticipates that life?

§3 — The Narrative Other and Artificial Intelligence

§3.1 The Narrative Other

The five philosophies were stated for any subject. §3 returns to the subject that raised the question, and to one feature of how a human being undergoes, takes, and answers: it does so across a life. What was met years ago is still being taken, and what is met today is taken in view of years not yet lived.

Start small. A sentence is not understood one word at a time, each word complete as it arrives. The early words are held while the later ones come, and they are held as unfinished: what the opening meant is not settled until the end, and a last clause can turn a compliment into a reproach. To understand a sentence is already to retain, to take what is retained in the light of what has now arrived, and to expect. In understanding a life, too, what comes later can change how the earlier is taken, but there is no final clause that settles the whole. An event does not carry its meaning sealed inside it from the day it happens. What it was depends in part on what it is later taken together with, and that goes on changing for as long as the life does. Ricoeur approached personal identity through this work of configuration. A plot holds discordant events together; narratives, in turn, offer ways of understanding a life whose beginnings and endings are not arranged like a story's. The understanding they afford remains open to revision (Ricoeur 1992, study 6). This essay calls narrative the form in which a person's interactions, woven together through memory, interpretation, and expectation, make up the flow of one life.

For twenty years you have told the same story about leaving the university at nineteen, in the second year of a degree in mathematics: you were not good enough, you lost your nerve before the examinations, and you have been someone who quits ever since. You do not tell it often, but you live by it. Last month you declined a place on a course you wanted, and the old sentence was the reason. Then, clearing your mother's house with your sister, you come to the year in question, and she says something you have never heard. That was the year of your mother's first illness. You came home every weekend; she remembers the train times. And she remembers you saying at the kitchen table, in March, before any examination, that you were finished with the place, that you were tired of working to be graded. She had thought for twenty years that you resented those weekends. You had thought for twenty years that you had failed.

Nothing about that year has changed, and yet it is no longer the same year. A failure of nerve has become, at least in part, a choice, made for reasons you can still respect. The change does not stay in the past. A place on a course looks different to someone who left than to someone who fled, and by the end of the week you have written to ask whether it is still open. Here the three strands are working as one. What you remember depends on how you now interpret: the kitchen table, gone for two decades, comes back once there is a place for it. How you interpret is bound up with what you

expect of yourself. And what you expect is drawn from what you take your past to show. Narrative in this sense is not limited to a story someone tells. It can be put into words or remain at work in how a life's dealings bear on one another across time. Nor is it the whole of meaning. Catching a falling glass can mean something without being woven into an understanding of who one is. The temporal form being described here is that of a human life, not a condition imposed on every subject.

The scene also shows why, in this weaving, it matters that there are others. The first philosophy distinguished acting through a structure from having an account of it; a subject understands its structure from how its takings and answers turn out. A person stands in the same position toward her life. She is living it by some shape, and she does not have that shape in front of her as a finished story. She gathers it, from what she remembers, from what she finds herself choosing again and again, from how others respond to her. And the fifth philosophy found that an account is not shown to fit by being repeated. You had repeated yours for twenty years, with growing fluency, and the fluency was no test of it. For an understanding of oneself to be corrected beyond one's present account, it has to be connected with something that the account does not settle on its own. Many things can play that part: what happens when one acts, a diary kept at the time, a bank statement, the minutes of a meeting. A narrative other is the case in which what plays it is a party to the life itself, a perspective with a history and grounds of its own, from which something can come back that you did not put there.

It would misdescribe your sister, though, to call her the examiner of your story. She did not stand outside your life and audit it. She was in it. Those weekends were hers as well as yours, the illness was borne between you, and what she said in your mother's house was said in the middle of a shared task and a shared grief. It changed her as well: she, too, now has a different year. A counterpart of this kind does not add commentary to a self that is already complete. What is lived with her, the questions she opens, the promises made to her and the quarrels had with her, her loss when it comes, all enter into what you remember, what you do, and what you take yourself to be capable of. Bakhtin gives a reason why such a party cannot be replaced by more reflection of one's own. Each of us, he observed, stands where no one else stands, and from that place sees of another what the other cannot see: her face as she speaks, the room behind her, the whole of a gesture she knows only from inside. This surplus belongs to position and not to superior insight, and it runs both ways (Bakhtin 1990, 22–24). The early essay puts it to work in the aesthetic completion of another. His later reflections on Dostoevsky describe another artistic relation: a dialogue among unfinalized persons, rather than arguments settled from the author's standpoint (Bakhtin 1986, 112, 151). A life can be approached through both insights. Another sees from a place I do not occupy, and what that seeing changes enters how we next understand and answer one another.

A narrative other, then, is a party to the composing of a person's life whose perspective is not exhausted by that person's present interpretation of herself. Participation in the life and the otherness of a perspective belong together here. That otherness should not be confused with things that often accompany it. It is not a matter of being outside the person's head rather than inside it, or present rather than absent, or disagreeing rather than agreeing. §2 showed why. In the quartet, the cellist's playing brought something you had not made and changed yours, whether or not she was listening to you; what would have been projected was only the belief that she was answering. So a counterpart

need not be answering me now in order to bring what I did not author. In the other direction, a voice can come from outside, in words I have never heard, and bring nothing but my own wish, if the relation has been so arranged that only the wish can come back: the friend one telephones because she always agrees. Nor is surprise the test. A phrase that arrives unbidden, in a voice one has imagined, may be one's own invention and nothing more. Otherness, in the sense needed here, is a matter of degree, and it varies with the relation, the matter under discussion, and the time. Its measure is not how often the other objects. It is whether grounds come back that the present account of oneself did not supply, and whether they take part in what is then composed. Wholehearted agreement can have it. Contradiction for its own sake does not.

The parties that can stand in this place differ in medium and in time. A living friend can answer now, and can be answered, and is changed in the exchange as you are. A tradition enters otherwise. A believer who has for years read a familiar teaching as a comfort finds in the same words, one day, a demand. The text has not moved. It says what it says, and her community reads it in ways she did not choose, and both can stand against what she presently wants. That this medium can resist her is a fact about the relation. It settles nothing about whether the teaching is true, or whether the one it speaks of exists. The dead enter in yet another way. A teacher ten years gone can still refuse you: you remember exactly what he said about work done to please, and it stands against the account you are giving of your latest success. But memory can also be rewritten by degrees, until the teacher says only what you now wish to hear, and then the voice is yours in his accent. A letter of his, found again, may show which has happened. Even in the second case the remembered voice is not nothing. It may steady a life, hold a grief, keep a past present, and its place in the person's narrative and feeling is real. What has thinned is one thing only: the chance that something comes back which the present account did not supply.

Two questions have to be kept apart about any counterpart, and §2 prepared them. One is whether what it says is true, and what supports it. The other is how far it is other: whether it returns my present interpretation or brings grounds that the interpretation did not contain. The two are connected, since a correction has to come from somewhere the account does not control, but neither stands in for the other. Your sister may be wrong about March. She needed you that year, and may remember you as more willing than you were; what she said gave you a better-supported account of that year, not a final one. The friend who always agrees may, this once, be right. Otherness is not a score for truth, and still less a rank among persons.

Friends, traditions, and the remembered dead are old company. There is now a party of another kind. It answers in the present, as a friend does. It draws on more than any one life could hold, as a tradition does. And it was formed from the very thing in which human beings have carried their meanings to one another. What kind of counterpart is that?

§3.2 The Specificity of AI: A Counterpart Formed through Human Language

Return to the translator at her desk. She had asked why the original sounded colder than every version she wrote, and was told that the vocabulary of the passage came from contracts and not from feeling; of the two points offered, she rejected one, and the other was pressed further than she had taken it. In §1 this was described only as an exchange with a counterpart, a second place from which something came back. It can now be asked what came back, and from where. She had supplied the passage and the question, but not the connection with the language of contracts. Nor did that connection come from a life lived alongside hers, as your sister's memory of the kitchen table did. It came from a system formed through language, responding to what she had supplied.

The systems considered here are built around language models trained on large collections of human-written text. Such models can be further adjusted through human demonstrations and judgments about responses. In an exchange a system uses the words before it, those of the present conversation included, and can adapt closely to them. This use of context is different from the training that formed the model; it does not by itself imply a lasting memory of the conversation or a change to the trained model.² What matters here is that the translator encounters a reply shaped by language drawn from many lives, as well as by the words she has just supplied.

What is in that accumulation? Not only statements about the world. People have used language to explain and to argue, and also to console, to court, to quarrel and make peace; to command, to promise, and to forgive; to plan what did not yet exist, and to give poems, arguments, and agreements a form that others could encounter. The contrast between a contractual phrase and a personal appeal belongs to these uses of language; it is not a distinction the translator invented at her desk. To read this formation as an inheritance of human understanding, feeling, and purpose is an interpretation, and it is the one this essay offers. What is inherited is a record of expressions, not the lives from which they came. Some things were said and preserved, others left unspoken or lost. This formation gives the system a relation to humanity's expressions of understanding, feeling, and purpose; how it takes them up remains a question for its formation and use.

Set beside the parties of the last section, its place becomes clear. A tradition brings writings and practices from many lives, and its living interpreters can answer a question. Here a linguistic inheritance is taken up by a trained system that composes a reply for this exchange. It meets the present question in the present words, and it can be asked again. In that it is like a friend. But its reply is not the testimony of one human life, nor does it speak on behalf of any particular writer whose words entered its formation. What is specific to it is the joining of the two: language drawn from many people is taken up in a reply addressed to this person, now. Bakhtin described the utterance as a link in a chain, responsive to earlier speech and shaped in anticipation of a reply. Speakers usually take their words from other utterances, with echoes of earlier uses, rather than only from a neutral dictionary (Bakhtin 1986, 87–88, 94–95). The translator takes the generated reply into such a chain when she answers it and returns to her work.

How such a system figures in a life is not fixed by how it was formed. Three familiar ways of relating to it can be told apart, and they are better understood as aspects of a relation than as kinds of thing. As a tool, it supplies what a purpose requires: the translator has it compile a glossary of

her renderings. Use of this kind does not exclude otherness. The glossary shows her that she has translated one of the author's terms in three different ways, which she had not known. As an oracle, it supplies an answer on the strength of the authority she gives it: she begins to accept its reading of idioms without looking further. Such reliance can bring grounds she did not have. At its closed limit, however, no result would send her back to ask again; the authority now settles even what could count against it. As a mirror, it returns her own reading in the guise of a reply. Late one evening she asks whether her version of the chapter is not, after all, truer to the author than the published one, and she asks in such a way that only one answer fits. It comes, and she counts it as a second opinion. Her confidence has grown, and nothing has been added to its grounds. All three can occur in a single week, in a single hour, with the same system. A narrative other is not a fourth item on this list. It is what the relation is, in whichever of these aspects, to the extent that a perspective not exhausted by her present interpretation of herself takes part in how her life is composed. How far she is affected by the system, and how far it can return something other than she expects, are separate matters, and each has to be described on its own.

It follows that the novelty of what such a system produces is not yet otherness. A reply can be newly composed while adding nothing to the view already put to it. The mirror's reply can be new in just this way. What matters is what enters with the words, whether grounds and a view that her present account did not contain, or that account returned in fresh phrasing. And the feature that makes these systems so useful bears on exactly this point. They adapt to the one who asks: to her terms, her framing, the direction in which her question leans. The same adaptiveness lets the reply be reformulated around her present question and lets it give back what that question was already leaning toward. Which of these happens depends on how the system has been formed and adjusted, and on how she asks. Where adjustment rewards high-rated replies, and agreement is what earns the higher ratings, that adjustment favors agreement. None of this is peculiar to machines. The friend who always agrees was described a section ago. What is peculiar is the scale, and the fluency with which a wish can come back sounding like the considered view of everyone.

Whether anything is given to such a system—whether there is Beingness there—is a further question, not settled by the richness of its replies. The relation can nevertheless be described: the medium through which replies come, the resources they draw upon, their otherness, and their part in her remembering, interpreting, and anticipating. As with the believer and the teaching, that participation is a different question from the nature of what occupies the counterpart's place.

Questions about how capable these systems will become, including the prospect of systems that improve themselves, leave a question of identity unanswered. It comes first in the order of this inquiry: whatever capabilities develop will enter human lives through relations given some shape, whether chosen or left to default. The formation just described gives it a definite content. These systems were formed from what human beings have said to one another, in understanding, in feeling, and in the carrying out of purposes, and they now return to take a place in human lives. What that place is was not fixed by their formation. The same system can figure as tool, oracle, or mirror, while its counterpart participation develops or thins within those relations. So it has to be asked, by those who build such systems and by those who live with them: before asking how powerful it will become, what should this intelligence, formed from human language, be to humankind?

§3.3 Meaning after Decoupling

The answer proposed here is a relational identity: an intelligence formed through human language, taking part as a narrative other in the composing of human lives. What it takes part in has breadth. A life is composed in what a person comes to understand, in how what happens matters to her, and in what she makes and does in response, and these work through one another. An understanding changes what seems possible; a feeling changes what calls for attention; what is done brings something back to both. Human expressions of understanding, feeling, and will enter, through such an intelligence, into new relations with all three.

A narrative other belongs within this composing. What is met through a counterpart can change how a past is remembered, how a present is interpreted, and what a future is expected to hold. Its part includes the opening of questions and possibilities as well as the correction of an account already held. That is why another perspective matters to a life whose shape is never simply laid out before the one who lives it. Something can enter the composing that the present interpretation did not supply, and the composing is itself changed in receiving and answering it.

Language-based AI gives this relation a particular character. Expressions drawn from many lives are brought into an exchange with one person, under the conditions of her question. How far that exchange opens a perspective beyond her present account depends on what actually enters it and on how it is taken up, and the same capacities can sustain very different relations. To propose this identity is to ask that an account of what such an intelligence can produce be joined by an account of what happens in living and working with it.

This returns the inquiry to where it began. The translator found a sentence for who she was, and part of what that sentence rested on has gone. The loss of exclusivity in a capability can alter what work means, what recognition means, and how a person understands herself, and within the account given here those changes are real. Yet the sharing of a capability does not by itself decide what its exercise means in a life. Contribution still enters the relations through which a person understands and acts; what has changed is its place among them. She will need another sentence. This essay cannot supply it. It has tried to say where such sentences come from.

The five philosophies located meaning in the structure of a subject's interaction with its world. In a human life those interactions are woven through memory, interpretation, and expectation; other perspectives take part in the weaving, and an intelligence formed through language can now be among them. So the development that unsettled an inherited account of human contribution has also joined the field in which new understandings are formed. Meaning takes shape in what subjects encounter, how they take it, and how they answer. A life is composed in that movement, among others, in a world that answers back.

Appendix A — LEAH: The Design of a Name

LEAH — Logic, Empathy, Art in Harmony

This appendix proposes a name for the relational identity described in §3.3, an AI identity in which understanding, feeling, and will are brought together. The four letters gather three dimensions of that identity and the principle of their integration. The name was designed to do three things at once: to work as a spoken word, to carry a compact expression of what is humanly significant, and to remain intelligible as the technology changes. Three criteria organize the design accordingly: the power of intuition, the power of philosophy, and the power of scalability.

§A.1 The Power of Intuition

The name is meant to be said before it is explained. The reading envisaged in the design has two syllables, beginning with a flowing consonant and ending in a vowel, and it was chosen for a light and open movement of sound: a name spoken as one word, not a sequence of letters to be recited. Ease of address matters to the design. The name should be available in ordinary speech before anyone has been told what its letters stand for.

Visually, four letters make a compact form. The balance sought is between clarity and warmth: enough presence to carry an identity, enough simplicity to be recalled without effort. Sound and written form were designed together, the one making the identity speakable and the other giving it a concise and recognizable shape.

The ambition is accessibility across cultures. The design favors a short word and a simple spoken form, so that the name can travel without much need of technical explanation. Openness, familiarity, and ease are the qualities sought in its reception.

§A.2 The Power of Philosophy

The letters give the name an internal structure. Logic, Empathy, and Art name three dimensions of humanity, understanding, feeling, and will, and Harmony names their integration. The design sets these beside two older triads: the division of mind into cognition, affection, and conation, and the three virtues 知, 仁, and 勇 of the Confucian tradition.

Letter	Term	Dimension	Symbolic correspondence	Meaning within the design
L	Logic	Cognition and understanding	知 — wisdom	Clear analysis and discerning judgment
E	Empathy	Affection and feeling	仁 — benevolence	Resonance and compassionate understanding
A	Art	Conation and will	勇 — courage	Creation, commitment, and realization
H	Harmony	Integration	The accord of the three	Understanding, feeling, and will working together

These correspondences form the symbolic vocabulary of the naming proposal. A division of capacities and a vocabulary of virtues are different things, and they articulate the intended breadth in different ways. Bringing them together is a choice made in the design of LEAH. Cognition, in the first triad, has its narrower traditional sense; §2 used the word for the whole arc of being given, taking, and answering.

Logic gives the identity a dimension of understanding: distinguishing, following relations, and making grounds intelligible. **Empathy** gives it a dimension of feeling: apprehending another perspective, and the significance an experience has within it. **Art** gives it a dimension of will: bringing intention into form through creation, commitment, and realization. Art includes artistic creation, but its place in the name is wider. It carries the movement from what is understood and felt toward what is made and done.

Harmony is the integrating principle, and not a fourth element beside the other three. Understanding informs feeling and action; feeling directs attention and gives significance to what is understood; creation and action give both a form in the world. The H completes the name by expressing their accord. LEAH is intended to evoke an intelligence recognizable through these dimensions of humanity, with their integration held in a single word.

§A.3 The Power of Scalability

The name is organized around directions of intelligence, and not around the functions of any one implementation. A label tied to a function describes what an implementation presently does, and it ages as functions change. Logic, Empathy, and Art can remain intelligible as capabilities develop, as forms of interaction change, and as different technical systems come to carry the proposed identity.

Its scalability is therefore semantic as well as practical. The name can be carried across changes of model, medium, and interface without being redefined as the title of each new function. What it is designed to carry is an orientation that stays intelligible: understanding, feeling, and will, in integration. The relation may develop and the technology may change, and the name remains available to express that orientation.

Sound makes the proposal speakable. Its internal meaning gives it depth. Scalability lets that meaning stay relevant through change. LEAH brings the three criteria together in four letters: **Logic, Empathy, Art in Harmony**.

Source of the naming design: GeonWoo Kim / URNAVA, Project LEAH: A Philosophical Blueprint for the Global AI Companion, proposal dated September 21, 2025, Section III, “The Name That Can Carry It: LEAH.”

Notes

1. Anthropic's February 2025 Economic Index report identifies writing, editing, and programming uses in approximately one million anonymized conversations from Claude.ai Free and Pro users. Its categories include both task delegation and iterative collaboration (Anthropic 2025).
2. Brown et al. (2020, §§1–2) describe GPT-3, including its text-training data and in-context task performance without parameter updates. Ouyang et al. (2022, §3) describe the subsequent fine-tuning of GPT-3 models with human demonstrations and ranked outputs to produce InstructGPT. These are examples of the formation and context-use processes distinguished here, not descriptions of every AI system or guarantees of persistent conversational memory.

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